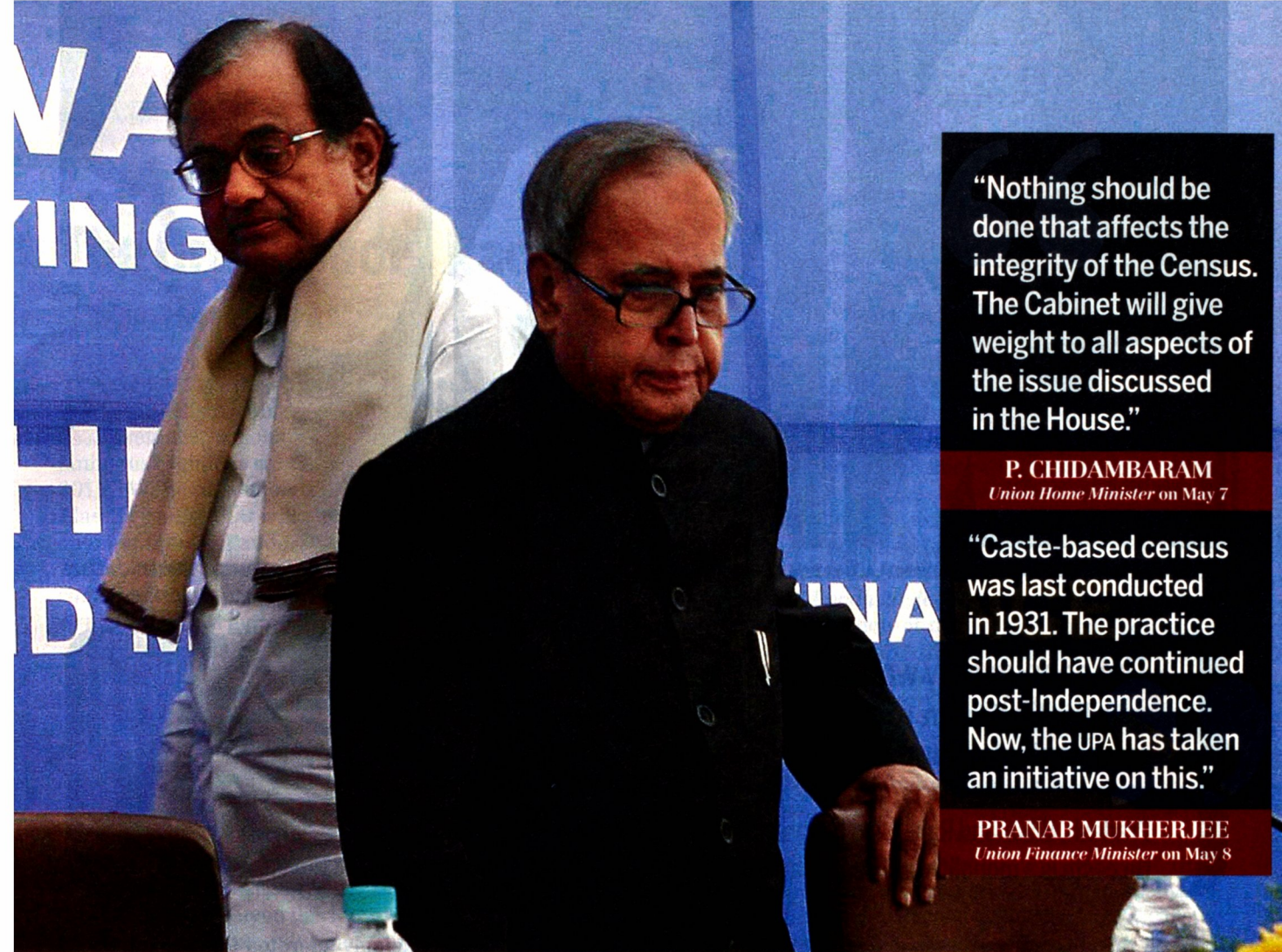




"Nothing should be done that affects the integrity of the Census. The Cabinet will give weight to all aspects of the issue discussed in the House."

P. CHIDAMBARAM

Union Home Minister on May 7

"Caste-based census was last conducted in 1931. The practice should have continued post-Independence. Now, the UPA has taken an initiative on this."

PRANAB MUKHERJEE

Union Finance Minister on May 8

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(LEFT) UNDER SONIA AND MANMOHAN, THE UPA REGIME HAS TAKEN THE RESERVATION ROUTE;
(ABOVE) PRANAB AND CHIDAMBARAM REPRESENT THE DIVERGENT VIEWS IN THE CABINET

could lead to the opening of a Pandora's box as it would unleash divisive forces which would later be difficult to contain. But they were in a minority. Apart from DMK ministers A. Raja and M.K. Azhagiri, even Congress ministers like Vayalar Ravi, Jaipal Reddy, Pranab Mukherjee and Veerappa Moily argued in favour of a caste census. An OBC himself, Moily had written to the prime minister six months ago stating that "the Centre does not have any caste-based data of its own. The Government has to depend on states for it. It is required for implementation of different schemes and employment programmes for the OBCs."

Ironically, though the late Rajiv Gandhi's reservations against the Mandal Commission's recommendations are

well-known, Sonia's Government is much more inclined to travel the reservation road, whether it is the Women's Reservation Bill or reservations in educational institutions. The UPA's Bharat Nirman programmes are also targeted at the weaker sections of society, the aam aadmi. Yet, many Congressmen complain that before taking such vital decisions, there was no Working Committee meet or even an informal discussion within the party. Bhakta Charan Das, a Dalit MP from Orissa, voiced his apprehensions in Parliament when he argued against what he called a "divisive" move. Politicians of all hues are only too aware that they are juggling a political hot potato that could blow up into Mandal-II, yet few among them in Parliament

Caste has anyway been an instrument of state policy. The best way to deal with the discrimination discourse is with facts. The caste census may well show that OBCs are well represented in government jobs. Also it has to be a secular exercise. Caste exists among Christians, Muslims and Sikhs, not just in India but across South Asia. We can no longer work through colonial categories. We need to show regional variations, because sometimes names of some castes are found in both the list of SCs and OBCs. Who knows, 30 per cent Indians may well refuse to declare their castes, which is a progressive sign. We have a robust social scientist community and a powerful public voice. We can produce an accurate description.

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